



STATUS REPORT

Benin — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-08-20 · compiled from the Data Landscapers source base

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The network now passes most of the country while most people are still not on it: 4G population coverage reached 88 per cent in 2024, up from 62 per cent in 2020, against an estimated 34.0 per cent of the population using the internet in early 2023, around 4.6 million people. Unique mobile subscribers numbered 8.5 million at the end of 2023, a penetration rate of 67 per cent, and entry-level mobile data cost more in 2022 than the international affordability threshold.

Benin's IIAG Mobile Communications score rose 26.7 points over 2014-2023 to 69.6 out of 100, 24th of 54, while Internet and Computers stood at 34.6 out of 100 in 2023, also 24th of 54, after a 17.4-point rise. Infrastructure remains the country's worst-scoring IIAG sub-category at 42.3 out of 100 in 2023, 21st of 54, despite the second-largest decadal gain of its 16 sub-categories. Public opinion runs ahead of the measurement: the Public Perception of Infrastructure score rose 41.4 points to 62.0 out of 100 in 2023, 8th of 54.

The backbone is externally financed; the domestic exchange layer is thin. Chinese concessional lending funded the first phase of the National Broadband Network Project — rehabilitation of the Cotonou-Malanville fibre backbone, a Cotonou metropolitan loop, followed by a densification phase implemented by the Agence du Numérique, and the West Africa submarine cable lands at Cotonou, its northern segment in service since April 2022. Benin-IX in Cotonou, established in December 2013, is still the only operational internet exchange point, with a small number of local networks participating alongside international peering nodes.

Access remains urban-weighted, with the rural gap acknowledged in the government's own 2031 strategic vision. Subscription is now tied to identity: SIM cards unregistered against the national identity system were deactivated from 30 April 2025. ECOWAS ministers meeting at Cotonou in October 2024 required all mobile operators to implement the regional roaming regulation by the end of 2025, and Benin is one of three beneficiaries of the World Bank's WARDIP2 programme, approved in March 2026 to fund broadband and digital public services.

Data Storage

Benin's public estate runs from a single site, and is now looking for a second: the national data centre at Abomey-Calavi, built to Tier 3 standard and operated by the state telecoms operator SBIM since around 2021, was joined in 2026 by a World Bank-funded feasibility study for a redundant national data centre. Behind that facility there is no

shared platform: as at 2025 there was no cloud platform available to all government entities, no government cloud hosting policy, and nothing published on government cloud usage, security or savings. The national artificial intelligence and big data strategy plans to equip the data centre with cloud and AI-as-a-service capability for hosting public-sector systems, and the West African Development Bank is financing modernisation and redundancy of the finance ministry's own data centre over 2026-2027.

There is no commercial fallback in country. West Africa hosts no public cloud region from any of the top five hyperscalers, directory listings record no direct cloud on-ramps in Cotonou, and Beninese enterprises reach AWS, Azure and Google Cloud remotely through Lagos (2026).

The rules on where data may sit are permissive: Benin imposes no data localisation requirement on personal or other data (2024). The one boundary drawn so far is around generative AI, where an ASIN instruction of June 2026 prohibits transferring administration data to extraterritorial jurisdictions while conceding that contractual terms do not close the sovereignty risk, because the model, the infrastructure and the governing jurisdiction all remain another party's. Volume is about to rise: a joint ministerial circular of 24 July 2026 requires every state structure to move archive and procedure management onto digital tools.

Energy

Power, not bandwidth, is the binding constraint on always-on services: firms reported 7.8 electrical outages a month in the 2024 World Bank Enterprise Survey. Electricity reached 57.0 per cent of the population in 2023, split 70.3 per cent urban against 43.7 per cent rural, a gap of 26.6 percentage points that rural electrification investment has been narrowing. Access to Energy is one of Benin's ten worst-scoring IIAG indicators at 22.7 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54, and it improved only 4.5 points over the decade.

That shows up wherever a public service meets the grid. Digitisation of health data capture in rural facilities is held back by unreliable electricity and internet access as much as by staff skills (2025), and only a minority of primary schools had electricity in 2021, with rural schools far behind and most without computers, so data entry by rural school directors depends on periodic access to a district office or a personal device.

Domestic generation is almost entirely non-renewable: renewable sources accounted for 0.26 per cent of domestic electricity output in 2021, and the share has not exceeded 3.4 per cent since 1990. Distributed supply has a policy vehicle behind it, an off-grid clean energy facility combining geospatial planning with deployment subsidies (2020). The grid's own instrumentation improved with the national electricity dispatch and control centre at Akassato, inaugurated on 22 June 2023, which brought real-time supervision, remote switching and fault detection to the national distribution network. Energy statistics themselves score below the built environment and natural resources in the 2024 Open Data Inventory.

Technical Capacity

The state is building a security-engineering cadre and has redefined what it is for: ASIN's position is that the information-system security officer's role has moved from managing antivirus and firewalls to strategic advice, and that an officer still doing ordinary IT work is the failure mode the programme exists to prevent (2026). Intake to the certification programme has been opened beyond central government to local authorities, state enterprises and the private sector, so the cadre is being assembled as an ecosystem rather than a civil-service grade.

The academic pipeline behind it exists without international standing: a dedicated national science and technology university founded in 2016, the IFRI computing institute and EPAC engineering faculty at Abomey-Calavi, an engineering and data-science institute at Sèmè City, and dozens of private computing and telecommunications programmes (2025). The working developer base it feeds is small and still emerging (2025), and where the state builds at scale it still buys the engineering — the biometric passport renewal application was developed by an external vendor.

Government's own measured readiness sits in the middle band of the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024. A government strategy for public-sector digital skills covers both advanced skills and basic digital literacy, with no results published against it (2025). Capacity is being pushed outward as well as upward: the World Bank delivered 2,050 biometric enrolment terminals in October 2024, equipping registration points rather than only central offices, and the University of Abomey-Calavi trained administrative staff across its faculties before switching document requests onto a single platform in July 2026. Outside the capital the floor is lower, with limited ICT skills among rural health staff holding back digitisation alongside power and connectivity (2025).

Cybersecurity

Benin published its first national report on the vulnerabilities of Beninese cyberspace at Cotonou on 25 June 2025, recording 878 vulnerabilities over 2021-2024, 23 per cent of them rated critical and 832 password breaches, attributed to outdated software, weak awareness and missing patches, with compliance against the state information-system security policy varying widely across public institutions, the public service sector worst affected. That sits beside a score of 91.54 out of 100 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index in 2024, the second-highest in Africa.

The institutional stack is real. A national digital-security strategy has run since 2020, under which the country has stood up a national CSIRT, a national public-key infrastructure, a forensic-analysis laboratory and a critical-infrastructure protection policy, with coordination through ASIN and CNIN and the national data centre behind them. Binding law comes from the consolidated Digital Code, whose Article 427 requires every data controller, payment providers included, to notify the supervisory authority and the affected person of a breach without delay. ASIN has given institutional security officers a common risk-analysis method, run a table-top crisis-management exercise with FIRST in March 2025 and trained unit heads of the Republican Police in 2026; Benin was among the African countries covered by Interpol's Carton Rouge 2.0 cybercrime operation in February 2026.

What none of it yet reaches is the core of government's own estate. Across the financial management system, the treasury single account and the customs, tax, human resources and payroll systems, the 2025 assessment records no governance arrangements for operations covering compliance, security, registers and audit trails; only e-procurement has them, and they are internal and unpublished. Meanwhile the attack surface widens as public services move online, with priority structures placed under tailored oversight (2026), and public agents already use generative AI tools on personal accounts outside any official framework, which ASIN's instruction orders censured and migrated to secured arrangements.

Cotonou has turned this into a regional position, hosting the fifth Cyber Africa Forum on 24-25 June 2025, claiming the status of West Africa's cyber security hub and taking the sixth edition on 16-17 November 2026.

DPI

Data Exchange

Benin published the conditions of access to its national data exchange only in [July 2026](#), six years after the platform was created: a body must be registered in the Catalogue des solutions interopérables, must demonstrate data governance covering quality, reliability and lifecycle control, and must run infrastructure compatible with the Xroad-BJ architecture. Each individual exchange then needs [its own convention](#) naming the data exchanged, the purposes, the responsibilities of each party and the security measures applied, and a private body must obtain [authorisation from the data-protection authority before its first connection](#). The published rules state [no fee schedule, no processing time for an application, no count of authorised participants and no record of enforcement](#).

The platform was [instituted by décret n° 2020-209 of 18 March 2020](#) and is of X-Road lineage, [built on Cybernetica's UXP, with live platform statistics published at statistiques.xroad.bj](#) (July 2026). ASIN administers it while a [Comité national d'interopérabilité supervises it](#), keeping the supervising body distinct from the operator, and the accompanying Cadre d'interopérabilité [sets four levels of interoperability for public bodies and binds private bodies that provide a public service as well as public ones](#).

What crosses it is uneven. The [SECURROUTE application](#) gives the national transport agency, the tax directorate and the traffic police a shared dataset covering vehicle registration, roadworthiness inspection, insurance, tax and safety compliance — the country's most fully integrated cross-agency case, and one used for fraud detection (2024). The tax authority exposes [IFUONLINE, an API letting other administrations verify the authenticity of a taxpayer's identification number](#), and the [business register](#) and the [national cadastre](#) are catalogued as systems connected to the platform. [Health, social protection, agriculture, justice and public statistics remain under development](#), named as priority data categories in the 2025 national data strategy terms of reference rather than integrated into the exchange.

The World Bank's 2025 assessment records the [interoperability framework as extensively used](#), supported by a data quality framework, monitoring of the uptime of government information systems and guidance for replacing legacy systems; [monitoring of the framework's own usage, compliance and benefits is done internally and is not published](#).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Biometric enrolment in Benin's national register of natural persons has reached [close to 99 per cent of the population](#) (2024), but enrolment and a usable credential have come apart: a civil-society card drive across nine communes [found people enrolled years earlier turning up with fingerprints that no longer match and RAVIP numbers that no longer resolve](#) (May 2026), so registration in the database does not guarantee a document that works.

The system rests on [Law No. 2017-08 of 19 June 2017](#), which establishes the personal identification number and the national population register and creates ANIP, and which makes the [biometric national identity card compulsory for citizens aged 18 and over while treating both the card and the free NPI certificate as legal proof of identity](#). Enrolment captures a digital photograph and fingerprints of both hands, with no iris capture. ANIP is attached directly to the presidency and holds the population register, the civil registry and the electoral register as one [integrated system](#), its director general also serving as National Civil Registrar.

Holding the number is close to a condition of economic participation. Unregistered SIM cards were ordered deactivated from 30 April 2025, credit and microfinance institutions must accept ANIP's biometric documents for banking formalities, and the card is required to receive care under the ARCH health-insurance programme. ANIP delivered 10.5 million identification and civil-status services in 2025, 75 per cent of them through digital channels, and waived the fee on "C'est Moi" cards around the April 2026 presidential poll so that voters could still be identified.

Civil registration is the weaker leg. ANIP manages birth, marriage and death records alongside identity, holding them in two fully digital central databases, the RNPP and the RNEC, with 2,050 biometric terminals supplied in 2024 to register births directly from health facilities, and a one-stop-shop pilot launched in ten public health facilities in August 2025 lets parents receive a child's number by SMS without visiting the town hall. Benin's civil registration score stood at 62.5 out of 100 in 2023, 24th of 54 African states.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Benin carries 21.4 per cent of the WAEMU's e-money transaction volume but only about 7.5 per cent of the Union's transaction value (2024): money moves often here and in small amounts. Its share of Union volume fell from 22.2 to 21.4 per cent over the year, on the slowest volume growth in the Union at 11.29 per cent, even as registered merchant acceptance points rose 62 per cent on QR-code deployment. Seven e-money issuing establishments operate in Benin, of 69 across the WAEMU, and 11.65 million active mobile money accounts were counted at the end of 2025, with MTN holding roughly 51 per cent of them.

Benin is one of the eight WAEMU states on the BCEAO's interoperable instant-payment system PI-SPI, opened to the public on 30 September 2025, on which domestic transfers are free to the user. Deployment is partial: six participants were listed for Benin as at November 2025, and in June 2026 the central bank extended connection deadlines to 30 September 2026 for banks and e-money issuers and to 30 June 2027 for microfinance institutions.

The state collects digitally far better than it pays. 86.01 per cent of person-to-government revenue was collected digitally as at 31 December 2023, alongside 95 per cent of VAT and 35 per cent of property tax, and the tax online service portal offers registration, filing and payment. On the same date none of the beneficiaries of back-to-school bonuses, scholarships, pensions and other social transfers received a digital government-to-person payment, against a 2028 target of 95 per cent; the GBESSOKÉ safety net began monthly mobile-money transfers in September 2025, reaching 20,621 households across twelve pilot communes.

There is no payment-specific consumer protection regime: the 2024 WAEMU instruction on payment services imposes governance, internal control and data-consent duties on payment institutions but does not address disclosure, liability allocation or error resolution, and a national financial-sector complaints platform was only scheduled to launch in the first quarter of 2026. Users of ATMs and mobile money report recurrent failed transactions in which funds are debited without the transfer completing, with slow or absent reimbursement (July 2025).

Registries

Benin's third General Business Census found that only 11.7 per cent of the 215,755 enterprises enumerated in 2023-24 were registered in the trade register, and only 14.1 per cent held a tax identification number — both up sharply from 2008, and both still leaving the great majority of firms outside. Registration itself is not the obstacle: the [monentreprise.bj](#) platform issues trade register entry, the tax number, the legal notice and the labour declaration digitally, typically within three hours.

Land is thinner. The digital cadastre is operational in only 12 to 14 of the country's 77 communes, and against an agency estimate of nine million parcels nationally roughly 491,000 to 530,000 are registered, cadastral coverage of about five to six per cent (2025); what exists is published online at [cadastre.bj](#) on a standards-based land information system designed for interoperability. There is no operational national address register: a national street-naming and building-numbering strategy was approved in April 2026 for rollout first in Cotonou, Abomey-Calavi, Ouidah, Porto-Novo, Sèmè-Podji and Parakou.

Civil registration is where near-universal biometric enrolment fails to carry through. Of roughly 2.5 million births declared between 2021 and 2025, fewer than one million were actually registered, because parents had to make a second journey to an ANIP office to convert a declaration into a record. Moving the desk inside the maternity ward lifted registration to 76.56 per cent across ten pilot maternities over six months, though national generalisation slipped by three to four months into a consolidation phase (July 2026).

The population register doubles as the electoral roll, and 7,834,608 voters were registered for the January 2026 legislative elections against an estimated voting-age population of 7,599,871. The Registre Social Unique was formally established by the Council of Ministers in January 2026 and is already used to identify beneficiaries for free health-insurance enrolment; it collects each household's national identification number as a core field, and the tax register is tied to the same number, with an individual able to obtain a tax identification number within 24 hours by supplying theirs online.

Sectoral management information systems

Benin's health information system is still fed by paper at the point of care: a donor-funded project distributed 4,000 paper health registers to private facilities across the country for later transcription into the national system (2025), and DHIS2 use is confined to district-level aggregation and a small number of urban facilities that enter data directly, while rural primary healthcare clinics capture patient data on paper for later transcription upward.

Education has been pushed the other way by directive. A ministerial instruction of February 2026 requires every school director, rural circonscriptions included, to register and continuously update learner enrolment, class lists and teaching-staff records on the government's EducMaster/SIGE platform, on pain of sanctions; the platform underpins national education statistics, the primary-leaving certificate process and payroll oversight.

The public service runs a custom-built human resources management system with a self-service portal for employees and managers, and a payroll system linked to it, also custom-built, though the HR system does not use the national identity number as either a primary or a secondary identifier. Customs and tax each run a commercial off-the-shelf management system, each exchanging data with other government systems both through separate interfaces and through the government service bus, with the two administrations not merged, and the tax

administration's internal system SIGIBE is catalogued in the national interoperability inventory. A social insurance system providing public sector and other non-health pensions is in use, its pension management system exchanging data with other government systems (2025). Across these core systems the same assessment records no documented governance arrangements for operations covering compliance, security, registers and audit trails.

Policing gained a centralised Automated Fingerprint Identification System in September 2025, developed with Interpol and Thales support and housed at the Directorate-General's technical police unit in Cotonou, but it is a national forensic database and does not extend digital case recording to station level.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A joint ministerial circular of 24 July 2026 requires every state structure to move archive and procedure management onto digital tools, and the returns the government claims for it are fiscal and environmental — lower printing, physical-archiving and file-circulation costs and a reduced administrative carbon footprint — rather than better service to the citizen.

Benin has more than 230 dematerialised public services online (June 2026), which ASIN's leadership frames as a correspondingly widened attack surface, with around 40 priority structures placed under tailored security oversight. The World Bank's 2025 assessment records an online public service portal operating at transactional level, universally accessible across channels and designed with citizen and business involvement, but no government mobile app for reaching public services; a social insurance and pension portal in use; a job portal carrying public sector positions alongside other vacancies; and an e-procurement portal that publishes tender notices and contracts but does not publish to the Open Contracting Data Standard and does not exchange data with other government systems.

On the financial side a custom financial management system covers treasury operations and budget preparation for central government only, a treasury single account is only partially used by ministries, departments and agencies, with no interface linking the financial management system to central bank systems, and a debt management system covers both foreign and domestic debt, with no public investment management system at all.

Coordination is the gap that assessment names: Benin has an established government entity focused on GovTech and digital transformation, but no coordination body such as a steering committee or council leading GovTech initiatives, and no entity monitoring and reporting digital spending across the whole of government.

Putting a service online has not always reached the bottleneck it was aimed at: online residence-certificate applications left issuance still dependent on neighbourhood and village chiefs, with applicants reporting the same obstacles at that step as before (April 2025). Benin scored 0.4264 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, while Public Administration was its most improved IIAG sub-category over 2014-2023, up 17.6 points to 69.3 out of 100 and 7th of 54.

Governance

Legislation and regulation

The most recent change to Benin's binding digital law widened who the state counts: in June 2025 the National Assembly amended article 6 of the identification law to extend the biometric register beyond citizens to resident foreigners and Afro-descendants, creating a residents file with a distinct identification number for each category.

It amends a base that is unusually consolidated for the region. The Digital Code, Law No. 2017-20 of 2018, is a single statute covering broadband internet, cybersecurity, data centres and cloud services, data protection, digital identification, digital payments, electronic signatures and e-commerce, and it is revised rather than supplemented: Law No. 2020-35 of 6 January 2021 rewrote its Book V on personal data, which sits alongside the older Law No. 2009-09 of 22 May 2009 and carries the rights and the supervisory authority described below. Identity is the exception, with its own statute: Law No. 2017-08 of 19 June 2017 governs the identification of natural persons, the personal identification number and the national population register, and created ANIP. Government data exchange rests on secondary instruments rather than primary law — Decree No. 2020-209 of 18 March 2020 for the interoperability framework and Decree No. 2022-324 of 1 June 2022 creating ASIN to operate it — and that framework binds private bodies providing a public service as well as public ones.

Tax law is where the sector has most recently been reached: Benin levies a 1 per cent tax on large cash payments, and further taxation of the digital economy was before parliament in the amending finance bill as at June 2026.

The codified stack is narrow. Three instruments carry almost all of it — the 2018 Digital Code, the 2021 Sectoral Policy Statement and the 2023-2027 AI and Big Data Strategy — while most of the specialised areas an inventory would look for have no standalone instrument of their own, among them spectrum policy, infrastructure sharing, e-waste, critical information infrastructure protection, open banking, a startup act and an AI law. Where the code is silent, so is the statute book.

Strategies, plans and policies

Benin's 2026-2033 governing programme states no budget, no sequencing and no named implementing agency for any of its digital commitments, which is the pattern the whole strategy layer repeats: the documents accumulate, the delivery machinery behind them does not.

Strategy itself has been continuous for a decade. It runs from the Digital Sector Policy Document of 2016-2021 through the National Artificial Intelligence and Big Data Strategy 2023-2027, a strategic vision for 2031 set out in February 2026, and a national data strategy in preparation with Smart Africa under 2025 terms of reference. The 2021 Sectoral Policy Statement covers universal access alongside cybersecurity, data centres and cloud, and data protection, and the AI strategy is adopted and operational. Against that, the GovTech and digital transformation strategy is recorded as old and due to be updated (2025).

Ownership is clear at the top and thin below it. The whole-of-government approach is institutionalised and led by a designated ministry, but there is no cross-government forum at which senior digital officials work across departments, and reporting on progress is internal and unpublished (2025), and there is no coordination body steering GovTech and no entity tracking digital spending across government. A data governance body exists but sits

inside another institution, its strategy is in progress rather than adopted, and it publishes no report on its results or spending (2025). Cloud is the clearest hole: there is no shared cloud platform for government entities and no hosting policy (2025).

The agency running the estate frames the remaining task the same way. ASIN's director general puts the difficulty at governance and coherence across infrastructure already built rather than at further construction, and is drafting a national DPI roadmap around a "once-only" principle (July 2026). The newest instrument shows the gap between announcement and delivery: a joint circular of 24 July 2026 requires every state structure to move archive and procedure management onto digital tools, yet carries no stated deadline, budget line, definition of the documents in scope or compliance mechanism, and its own text was not published as at 31 July 2026.

Regional collaboration

The regional digital agenda Benin signs up to is not paid for by the region: ECOWAS's Community Budget 2026-2028 carries no disaggregated digital or ICT appropriation, and its only ICT-named programme line records nil spending from 2023 and none in the estimates to 2028, so the instruments Benin relies on are externally financed.

Benin nonetheless convenes more of the agenda than most of its neighbours. It hosted the West and Central Africa digital transformation summit in Cotonou in November 2025, at which ministers of the two regions adopted a declaration committing to a single digital market built on interoperable digital public infrastructure and 90% affordable broadband coverage by 2030, and to harmonising their cybersecurity, data protection and artificial intelligence frameworks. A year earlier, the ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024-2029 was adopted at Cotonou, and the same meeting required member states to have the ECOWAS Roaming Regulation fully implemented by all mobile operators by the end of 2025. Benin co-leads a six-country francophone West African framework on AI governance, taken to the UN Global AI Dialogue (July 2026), joined the 50-in-5 campaign in June 2026, and is committed under both the Malabo and Budapest Conventions.

What crosses the border is narrower than what has been declared. The physical identity card is ECOWAS-standard and accepted for travel across the fifteen-member region without a passport, but the digital layer above it does not run on ECOWAS machinery: the ECOWAS-World Bank WURI programme has validated a cross-border interoperability strategy and a 2026 work plan for mutual recognition of credentials, not an operating service, while the one arrangement that does carry credentials across a border reaches outside the region — Smart Africa and GIZ have a digital identity pilot running between Rwanda, Ghana and Benin, with eighteen further countries said to be joining, and no scale, service or date is given for any of it, and it does not extend to Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger, which severed their ECOWAS and WURI ties in 2024. Payments do cross, on infrastructure the region owns: the BCEAO operates as well as regulates the WAEMU clearing and settlement systems Benin uses, and its instant payment rail opened to the public in September 2025, with connection deadlines still running into 2027. Regional Integration is one of Benin's ten most improved governance indicators, at 65.9 out of 100 in 2023 and 3rd of 54 after a 24.7-point rise over the decade.

Standards

Benin publishes how badly its own institutions meet its security standard: [compliance with the state information-system security policy ranges from 6 per cent to 87 per cent across public institutions \(2021-2024\)](#), published by the state in [the first national report on the vulnerabilities of Beninese cyberspace, unveiled in June 2025](#).

The interoperability framework is the main standard-setting instrument, and specific where such documents are vague. It sets four levels — juridical, organisational, semantic and technical — with governance running across all of them, presents itself as recommendations while obliging public and private administrations providing a public service to observe its principles, and names the standards it requires rather than gesturing at them, citing W3C specifications including WCAG 2.0 for accessibility, ISO 10918, ISO/IEC 26300, MPEG4 and named RFCs. Around it sit a data quality framework, uptime monitoring of government information systems and guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025), and access conditions published in July 2026 requiring registration in the interoperability catalogue, demonstrated data governance and conformity to API and web-service standards.

Elsewhere the mandating is patchier. Benin has a unified budget classification and chart of accounts covering central government, and its financial management system exchanges data both through separate interfaces and through a [government service bus \(2025\)](#), and land records run on the e-Foncier project's LADM/ISO 19152 land information system. Procurement does not enforce standards on its own data: [the e-procurement portal publishes tender notices and contracts but not to the Open Contracting Data Standard](#), and does not exchange data with other government systems (2025). There is no government open source software policy or action plan for the public sector (2025).

Newer standards are set by instruction rather than by framework. ASIN's June 2026 instruction on generative AI requires a binding harmonised charter applying to public-service staff, providers and partners alike. On method, ASIN has given state security officers a common risk-analysis framework in EBIOS Risk Manager, and the certification programme for those officers, taught to Certified Ethical Hacker and ISO 27001, is the stated delivery arm of the national digital security strategy and of the state security policy itself.

Data protection

Benin's data protection authority is doing enforcement work, not just existing: [the APDP examined 907 compliance files in 2025 and validated 87.4 per cent of them, carried out 64 control missions, issued 75 conformity certificates and recorded 37 designated data protection officers, and sanctioned 14 cases](#). Its 2025 activity report, one of a published series, records 782 control and litigation cases and 20 privacy complaints instructed.

The regime it enforces is statutory. Personal data protection is governed by the law of 6 January 2021 within the Digital Code, which establishes the APDP as supervisory authority, with rights of access, rectification, objection, portability and erasure. The APDP is an independent administrative authority with legal personality; it supervises processing, investigates breaches and issues sanctions, including over the biometric identification system, and its decisions may be appealed to the competent administrative jurisdiction. Article 427 of the Digital Code requires every controller to notify the authority and the affected data subject without delay of a breach and its likely consequences. No data localisation requirement applies to personal or other data (2024).

The regulator sits inside the plumbing: a private body connecting to the national data exchange must obtain APDP authorisation before its first connection, and every exchange needs its own convention naming the data, the purposes and the security measures.

The sharpest current exposure is inside government itself. ASIN's June 2026 legal instruction on generative AI records that public agents already use such tools on personal accounts, outside any official framework, and orders their migration to secured arrangements. Provider contracts must carry a data-processing agreement and clauses forbidding any use of administration data to train or optimise models, and transfers of administration data to extraterritorial jurisdictions are prohibited — though ASIN concedes that contractual terms do not close the sovereignty risk, since model, infrastructure and jurisdiction all remain another party's.

Cooperation is being built outwards: the APDP and Senegal's data protection commission signed a cooperation convention in Cotonou in April 2026, and at a regional forum in Lomé in July 2026 it set out Benin's compliance record and pressed for harmonisation between African authorities.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Consultation is where Benin's governance record has fallen furthest: Deliberative and Participatory Governance is its fifth most deteriorated indicator, down 30.6 points over 2014-2023 to 49.2 out of 100 and 34th of 54, and Public Perception of Freedom of Speech is the fourth most deteriorated, down 32.7 points to 53.5. Both fell while the formal position held: Freedom of Expression and Belief remains one of the country's ten best-scoring indicators at 90.2 out of 100, 5th of 54, and Digital Freedom stood at 80.7, 9th of 54. What people feel able to say has moved faster than what the law allows.

The channels exist and terminate. National platforms let citizens and businesses take part in policy decision-making and accept anonymous submissions, but take no petitions, and the government's responses are not published (2025); separate platforms take complaints and information requests, support users with disabilities and carry published service standards (2025). But the government does not demonstrate that it changes services in the light of the feedback it receives (2025), and right-to-information legislation is in force while nothing is published on how it is working (2025). Accountability and Transparency is one of Benin's three worst-scoring governance sub-categories at 47.6 out of 100 in 2023, down 5.0 points over the decade.

Argument about digital policy happens largely outside the state's channels. Benin hosted the West Africa Feminist Data Summit in Porto-Novo in July 2026, convened by the Réseau des femmes leaders pour le développement on decolonising data, with tracks on digital censorship and shutdowns, technology-facilitated gender-based violence and press freedom, which produced policy briefs naming regulatory gaps alongside a regional feminist data agenda for 2026-2028. It adopted the Déclaration de Porto-Novo as a common reference framework for the region's feminist movements, and sat inside Nafasi, a Sida-funded continental programme running 2026-2029 to preserve the space in which civil society, journalists and women human rights defenders operate. Press capacity is growing: journalists were trained in Cotonou in March 2026 on biometric identity and personal data protection. Locally, grievances are concrete: access to civil-status records was under open dialogue in Godomey in June 2026.

Inclusion

Digital divides

The agency that has enrolled close to the whole population in the biometric register still describes Benin's rural areas as underserved by identification and civil-status services, and said so again in 2026. The same bias runs through the services built on top of the register: use of digital public services is concentrated in Cotonou and Abomey-Calavi, and the rural gap is acknowledged in the government's own strategic vision for 2031 (2025).

Beneath the services sits the physical divide. Urban households are considerably more likely than rural ones to have an electricity connection (2023), and internet use is still a minority of the population (2023), so the number of people who can reach a service online is a good deal smaller than the number the register holds. On the composite measure of internet and computer access Benin sits in the middle of the African field, having gained heavily over the decade to 2023 — a fast-closing gap on the continent and a wide one at home.

Language and skills are treated as divides in their own right. The voice artificial intelligence system in Fon, launched in June 2025, is built so that speakers who do not read, or do not use French, can reach digital services in their mother tongue. The government offers digital skills programmes to citizens and schools free of charge (2025) and has set up a digital innovation and inclusion lab under ASIN, against a connectivity and skills gap it accepts leaves digital public services only partly reachable (2025).

Access to services

Benin scores 60.3 out of 100 on equal access to public services, seventh of 54 African states and 3.4 points up over the decade (2023). Access increasingly runs through the identity credential: near-universal enrolment has made the national identification number the entry key to services well beyond government, from microcredit to a telephone subscription (2025), and the biometric card is required to receive care under the ARCH health-insurance scheme (2025).

Being in the register is not the same as holding a usable credential. A free-card drive across nine communes found people enrolled years earlier whose fingerprints no longer matched and registration numbers no longer resolved (2026). Cost bites too: ANIP waived the card fee around the April 2026 presidential poll and held its channels open until voting morning. An offline route survives where one has been built — the electoral platforms carry a USSD line for people with no internet access (2025) — but where the credential is missing altogether the exclusion is absolute: undocumented displaced people in the north cannot open mobile money accounts, so the World Food Programme distributes access codes to get cash assistance to them (2023). Law No. 2017-06 obliges private financial providers to accommodate persons with disabilities, though a government workshop in Cotonou in August 2024 was convened as a first stocktaking of exclusion still observed in the sector.

The counter where cash meets the digital system is being withdrawn. Benin's mobile-money distributor network shrank by 29.69 per cent in a single year, the steepest fall in the WAEMU after Mali, within a Union-wide contraction of 5.23 per cent the BCEAO attributes to lower fees and commissions paid to distribution networks alongside the closure of inactive points (2024). Government payment has moved the other way, slowly: social transfers were still not being paid digitally at the end of 2023, and the GBESSOKÉ safety net began mobile-money transfers in twelve pilot communes in September 2025.

The cash-out network and the merchant acceptance network moved in opposite directions in the same year: the counter where cash is exchanged is being withdrawn as the till is being wired.

Technology

AI

Artificial intelligence reached the field in Benin before it reached the administration. A [malaria programme combining artificial intelligence, drones and geospatial mapping](#), worth US\$2.3m and funded by Japan under TICAD, was running as at July 2026. A year earlier Benin launched [the first voice-to-voice artificial intelligence system in Fon](#), a national language, built with the Gates Foundation, IIDiA and the digital agency ASIN, and now extending to Senegal and Côte d'Ivoire (June 2025).

The policy frame is older than either. The [National Artificial Intelligence and Big Data Strategy 2023-2027](#) is adopted and operational, and it is where the compute question sits: the strategy sets out plans to equip the national data centre with cloud and AI-as-a-service capability for hosting public-sector systems. That is a plan for the hosting layer, not a hosting layer in place, and the distinction matters more here than in most chapters, because everything else the strategy proposes runs on it.

Governance arrived in 2026, and it arrived from the operational side rather than the legislative one. ASIN issued a [legal instruction governing the use of generative artificial intelligence tools by public agents](#) across the administration in June 2026, prompted by agents already using such tools on personal accounts outside any official framework. Beyond the border, Benin [co-leads a six-country francophone West African framework on AI governance](#) with Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Mali and Senegal, which the group has taken to the UN Global AI Dialogue (July 2026), and the ECOWAS digital roadmap of January 2026 [sets a regional AI governance framework for West Africa as a target](#).

ICT Industry

The state's own technology is substantially supplied from outside the country: the [biometric passport renewal app](#), the identity front door for citizens abroad, was built by a Nigerian vendor on its own platform (December 2025). The domestic bid is narrower and more recent. Benin has chosen [cyber security start-ups](#) rather than procurement alone as its route to capability in that field (April 2025), and is [pitching itself as West Africa's cyber security hub](#) through the Cyber Africa Forum (June 2025).

Two conditions sit under any of it. Most firms enumerated in the [2023-24 general business census](#) were outside the trade register, so the formal base a technology sector would be counted within is thin, and firms report [frequent electrical outages](#), which constrains any always-on service built domestically (2024).

Innovation ecosystem

The state agency now runs an incubator itself. [Cyber Incub](#), a cyber-security-only start-up incubator run by ASIN with ADPME and CNIN and backed by Luxembourg's LuxDev through its BeDigital programme, took ten teams through maturation at Abomey-Calavi and awarded three winners 10 million FCFA each (April 2026). Alongside it, [ASIN's HackerLab competition](#) has drawn more than 500 entrants (2025), and [several technology hubs](#) operate alongside the state-backed Sèmè City campus (2024).

What that machinery is not doing is producing a broad base of financed firms. [Start-up funding is concentrated in a very small number of large deals](#), led by e-mobility and ride-hailing ventures (2025), and the [developer community the ecosystem draws on remains small](#). Benin ranked [119th on WIPO's Global Innovation Index](#) in 2024, in the bottom quartile.

The government's own instruments have the shape of a system without the evidence of one working. There is a [policy to support GovTech start-ups and financing for start-up and SME innovation](#), but no procurement policy reserving or prioritising bids for start-ups and small firms — so the state supports the sector as a funder without using its own purchasing to do it — and no results are published on the support given (2025). The pattern repeats inside the administration: [an established government entity for public sector innovation and a strategy behind it](#), and [collaboration with the private sector recorded as a standing mechanism](#) rather than a one-off, with nothing published on what either has produced (2025).

External money is arriving for specific institutions rather than for the ecosystem at large, including [a timbuktoo innovation lab at the University of Abomey-Calavi](#) with prototyping labs and incubation attached.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

[The Millennium Challenge Corporation paid for Benin's first national electricity dispatch and control centre at Akassato](#), a USD 31.4 million activity within the USD 391 million Benin Power Compact, inaugurated on 22 June 2023.

American aid money reaches Benin's health data through implementing contractors, and what it buys is not always digital: [a USAID-funded project supplied private health facilities with paper registers for later transcription into the national health information system](#) (2025), rather than extending data entry to the facilities themselves.

China activities

Benin's fibre backbone was built on Chinese concessional credit. [China Eximbank signed a CNY 496 million \(about USD 89 million\) government concessional loan on 7 April 2015 for the first phase of the National Broadband Network Project](#), on 20-year maturity with a seven-year grace period at 2 per cent interest, financing a Huawei contract with Benin Telecom to rehabilitate the Cotonou-Malanville backbone and build a metropolitan loop in Cotonou.

[The second phase, densifying that network, again runs on a China Eximbank concessional loan](#), with the Agence du Numérique as implementing agency (2022).

Eleven distinct financiers appear across the external commitments to Benin's digital sector, and China Eximbank stands among the largest by value committed on the strength of these two loans alone.

EU activities

European money sits behind Benin's newest police biometric system: [the automated fingerprint identification system inaugurated on 30 September 2025 connects to the ECOWAS SIPAO police data-exchange network, which is EU-funded and implemented by Interpol.](#)

Germany funds two of the standing programmes. [BMZ pays for BenInnovation, a EUR 6.5 million programme running from 2022 to 2026 on the structuring of the digital sector](#), behind the government's stated goal of making Benin the digital platform of West Africa, and [a further EUR 9 million over the same four years for micro, small and medium-sized enterprises](#), where digitalisation skills sit among the gaps it addresses alongside business planning, product development and marketing.

Smaller European positions run through national development agencies rather than Brussels. [Luxembourg's LuxDev backs Cyber Incub, the cybersecurity-only start-up incubator run by ASIN with ADPME and CNIN \(April 2026\)](#), and [Belgium's Enabel ran DigiBoost, a grant and technical support programme for the organisations that support digital startups and small firms, from 2019 to 2023.](#)

India activities

No Indian party held an established position in Benin's digital sector - infrastructure, platform deployment, financing or bilateral agreement - as at August 2026.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-based operator held an established position in Benin's digital sector - infrastructure, operator holding, financing or agreement - as at August 2026.

Capacity

Literacy

Benin's schooling is now judged better than it is attended: [assessed education quality rose 23.0 points over 2014-2023 to rank seventh of 54 African countries, one of the country's ten most improved governance indicators](#), while over the same decade [enrolment and completion both fell and sit among Benin's worst scores, 34th and 30th of 54 respectively.](#)

[Human Resources in Education held a stronger position, 31st of 54, but it fell too, by 15.9 points across the decade.](#) The improvement in judged quality is therefore sitting on top of a system reaching fewer children, taught with thinner inputs than it had ten years earlier.

On digital literacy the state's provision is at least free at the point of use: [the government offers digital skills programmes to citizens and to schools at no charge \(2025\)](#). It has also begun building around the reading barrier rather than only through it — [a Fon-language voice assistant is designed so that speakers who do not read, or do not use French, can reach digital services in their mother tongue \(June 2025\)](#).

The classroom itself remains largely off the system while the administration above it moves online. [In rural primary schools in Atacora and Atlantique departments, attendance call registers and in-class monitoring are still run on paper \(2026\)](#). At the other end of the education system, [from 31 July 2026 the Université d'Abomey-Calavi requires degree certificates, transcripts, enrolment certificates and diploma duplicates to be requested through an online platform, with the physical counter retired](#).

Training and skills

Benin is assembling a state cyber security officer corps to a stated headcount: [the target is 100 qualified information-system security officers by the end of 2026, and the August 2026 cohort took the country to roughly 85 trained](#). That cohort was [25 officers, drawn from more than 200 applications, on a four-week certifying course opened in Cotonou on 3 August 2026 teaching Certified Ethical Hacker and ISO 27001, with practical work at the national Cyber Range](#). Intake has been opened beyond central government to local authorities, state enterprises and the private sector, and the programme is the stated delivery arm of the national digital security strategy, [building the cadre as an ecosystem rather than a civil-service grade](#).

ASIN's other training runs wide of that cadre. [It trained 300 unit heads of the Republican Police in cyber security and sensitive-data protection in June 2026, ran a table-top crisis-management simulation for state security officers in March 2025 with FIRST, the global incident response forum, and runs a HackerLab competition alongside the Cyber Africa Forum that has drawn more than 500 entrants \(2025\)](#).

The pipeline behind it is real: [a dedicated national science and technology university, UNSTIM, founded 2016, the IFRI computing institute and EPAC engineering faculty at Abomey-Calavi, a new engineering and data-science institute at Sèmè City developed with France's Centrale Group, and dozens of private institutions offering computing and telecommunications degrees](#). The state also runs a job portal reachable across channels, handling registration, search and application online and carrying public sector vacancies [\(2025\)](#), designed without involving the people who use it.

[A government digital skills strategy for the public sector covers both advanced skills and basic digital literacy \(2025\)](#). Beyond it sit commitments rather than programmes: [under the Cotonou Declaration of November 2025 Benin and the other signatories undertook to equip 20 million people across West and Central Africa with basic digital skills, place 2 million in digital jobs, and produce national digital compacts by 2028, and the 2026–2033 programme put to voters by the Wadagni–Talata ticket promises mass training in artificial intelligence, data science and robotics through Sèmè City](#).

Research institutions

The largest identifiable addition to Benin's research capacity is externally funded: [UNDP is putting USD 3 million over 2022–2026 into a timbuktoo innovation lab at the University of Abomey-Calavi, adding a digital innovation and technology research module with prototyping labs, technology incubation and an entrepreneurship ecosystem](#).

It lands on a teaching base with some depth — a dedicated national science and technology university, UNSTIM, founded 2016, the IFRI computing institute and EPAC engineering faculty at Abomey-Calavi, and a new engineering and data-science institute at Sèmè City developed with France's Centrale Group — but one whose output does not yet register internationally: Benin ranked 119th on WIPO's Global Innovation Index in 2024, in the bottom quartile.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

A ministerial directive of February 2026 now requires every school director in Benin, rural circonscriptions included, to [register and continuously update learner enrolment, class lists and teaching-staff records on the government's EducMaster platform, on pain of sanctions](#), with national education statistics, the primary-leaving certificate and payroll oversight resting on what they enter. It is an obligation placed on schools where [most have no computers](#) and where electricity is the exception.

Capture has moved further in the health system, and through health facilities rather than local government offices. Since October 2024 [mobile registration terminals have been distributed to facilities across all of Benin's districts](#) for direct digital entry into the national population and civil status registers, and in August 2025 the identification agency [opened a one-stop-shop pilot in public health facilities, including hospitals serving rural catchments at Natitingou, Djougou and Borgou-Alibori, under which parents receive their child's identification number by SMS without visiting the town hall](#). The clinical record itself is untouched: DHIS2 use is confined to district-level aggregation and a few urban facilities entering data directly, while rural primary healthcare clinics capture patient data on paper for later transcription upward, and the response to weak private-facility reporting was to distribute paper registers rather than extend digital entry. The binding constraints are [unreliable electricity and internet access and limited ICT skills among rural health staff](#), and the agency responsible [still treats rural areas as underserved by identification and civil status services](#). Land data is worse served still: [the digital cadastre reaches only a minority of communes](#).

The rural economy this data describes has barely moved. Benin's Rural Economy sub-category in the Ibrahim Index scored [63.9 out of 100 in 2023, 23rd of 54 and up only 2.4 points over the decade](#) — the smallest gain of any sub-category in the two categories where the country improved. Within it, [rural market access is the only measure to have fallen over 2014-2023, down 9.3 points to 37.8 and 30th of 54, against rural land and water access at 75.6 and rural representation and participation at 76.9](#).

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The financial spine of the Beninese state stops at the centre: the [financial management information system covers treasury operations and budget preparation for central government only \(2025\)](#), so what the 77 communes run on is not part of it. Nor do they have the foundational registers a local administration works from. [No operational national address register exists](#): a strategy to standardise street naming and building numbering was approved by the Council of Ministers in April 2026, to be rolled out first in Cotonou, Abomey-Calavi, Ouidah, Porto-Novo, Sèmè-Podji and Parakou, and the country still relies on informal landmarks and post-office boxes. The [digital cadastre was operational in 12 communes, covering more than 491,000 registered parcels, with a dedicated project running to June 2026 still preparing the nationwide scale-up \(2025\)](#).

Where national platforms do reach the communal tier they reach it as delivery channels rather than as local capability. The GBESSOKÉ social safety net began monthly electronic cash transfers by mobile money in September 2025, reaching 20,621 households, 85 per cent of them headed by women, across twelve pilot communes, with beneficiaries issued dedicated SIM cards, and is scheduled to scale to around 150,000 households across all 77 communes. Civil registration runs the same way: e-SIRCEV, launched in 2019, assigns a unique identification number at birth through the registration centres, a national system operated locally rather than a communal one.

The limit of that model shows where a national service still depends on a local official. Putting residence-certificate applications online has not removed the bottleneck: issuance still depends on neighbourhood and village chiefs, and applicants meet the same obstacles at that step as before digitisation (April 2025). Access to civil-status records remains a live local grievance, with communal authorities in Godomey holding an open dialogue with residents about it in June 2026. One thing is being built deliberately across the tiers: intake to the information-security officer certification programme has been opened beyond central government to local authorities, state enterprises and the private sector (August 2026).

Data

National statistics

Two of the five survey types the World Bank tracks went entirely unsupplied in Benin over the ten years to 2023: no agricultural survey and no business or establishment survey were run in that period, and data sources is the weakest of the statistical system's five pillars, in the 20-49 per cent band against data use above 89 per cent, data products in the 70-89 per cent band, and data services and data infrastructure both between 50 and 69 per cent (2023). The state is markedly better at using statistics than at collecting them.

The enumeration base is in better order. A population census and an agricultural census were both run within the ten years to 2023, while the business census fell outside that window, and household and health surveys were each conducted three or more times over the same period, with two labour force surveys. The enterprise gap has since been addressed on the census side, with INStAD's third general business census in the field in 2023-24.

The office itself is getting stronger: capacity of the statistical system rose 14.1 points over 2014-2023, ranking Benin 19th of 54 African countries. Administrative data cannot yet substitute for survey collection, though. Civil registration remains incomplete, the great majority of enumerated enterprises sit outside both the trade register and the tax register, and rural clinics still capture patient data on paper for later transcription upward rather than entering it into the national health information system. Public statistics is named as a priority category for the data exchange but is not yet integrated with it (2025).

Where the state does measure its own performance, it does so through the budget: the financial management information system captures expenditure linked to the Sustainable Development Goals extensively, and non-financial performance indicators for most government programmes and projects (2025).

Open data

Benin discloses public records comparatively well, 11th of 54 African countries in 2023 and up 8.2 points over the decade, yet reaching those records is among its ten worst-scoring governance indicators, 34th of 54 despite a 9.6-point decade improvement. Publication is not the binding constraint; access is.

What is published best is financial and agricultural. Balance of payments, banking and monetary statistics, and agriculture and land use each score 7 out of 10 for coverage and openness in 2024, while government finance statistics are the weakest of all 22 categories at 3 out of 10, with national accounts at 4.5 and trade and labour at 5. The state publishes least well on its own money. Social coverage sits in between — education facilities and outcomes at 6.5, population and gender statistics at 5.5, health facilities at 5, health outcomes at 4.5 and crime at 4 — as does the environment, with energy at 4.5, pollution at 5, the built environment at 5.5 and natural resources at 6 (2024).

Across the 22 categories assessed in 2024, the scores run from 3 to 7 out of 10 and average 5.4, and none reaches 7.5. The ceiling is low across the board.

The open data portal is refreshed weekly to daily but carries only basic information and datasets, and is updated mostly by hand rather than dynamically through APIs (2025). The right to ask for what is not published exists on paper: right-to-information legislation is in force, makes information available digitally, and has an entity monitoring its implementation, but nothing is published on requests received, granted or refused. The same pattern runs through the systems themselves — monitoring of the interoperability framework's usage, compliance and benefits is done internally and not published, and the e-procurement portal publishes tender notices and contracts but not to the Open Contracting Data Standard (2025).

Of the sixteen transparency measures in the 2025 GovTech assessment, exactly one records something actually published — the service standards attached to citizen feedback. Twelve record no publication at all, and three record reporting that exists but is kept internal.

Use of satellite data

A US\$2.3m malaria programme funded by Japan under TICAD combines artificial intelligence, drones and geospatial mapping to target mosquito breeding sites (July 2026). Beyond that donor-funded project, no national position on Earth observation or geospatial data use — an agency, a receiving facility, a policy — was established as at August 2026.

Finance

New investments

Benin is one of three beneficiary countries of WARDIP2, a USD 137 million World Bank-financed regional programme approved on 11 March 2026 to fund broadband and digital public services across Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone, having been absent from the borrowers of the programme's first tranche, a USD 266 million operation whose borrowers are The Gambia, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau and Mauritania. The West African Development Bank

agreed to lend XOF 19.5 billion, about USD 32 million, over 2026-2027 to digitalise the Ministry of Economy and Finance, covering the ministry's data centre, the post office's information system and the development-finance and HR systems (May 2026).

Fifteen distinct digital-sector financing commitments to Benin are on record as at August 2026, spanning 2015 to 2030, twelve of them Benin-specific and three regional West Africa operations. They come to around USD 770 million in announced value, around USD 320 million of it committed to Benin alone; the rest sits in regional totals covering four to seven countries. Eleven financiers appear, led by the World Bank with three commitments and China Eximbank and Germany's BMZ with two each. Grants are the most common instrument, at eight of the fifteen, but the loans carry the larger sums, and connectivity takes the largest share of the money. Four of the fifteen were announced in 2026 alone, more than in any earlier year.

The largest single commitment reaching Benin is [WURI-2](#), a USD 273 million World Bank operation running 2020-2027 under which Benin borrows alongside Burkina Faso, Niger and Togo to expand foundational digital ID. The largest Benin-specific one is the [Digital Rural Transformation Project](#), USD 100 million over 2019-2025, for digital agriculture, rural broadband and financial inclusion. Older money is Chinese: [China Eximbank signed a CNY 496 million concessional loan on 7 April 2015](#), on 20-year terms with a 7-year grace period at 2 per cent, for the Cotonou-Malanville fibre backbone, then [financed a second phase densifying the network](#). [Maroc Telecom's EUR 150 million West Africa submarine cable](#) lands at Cotonou (April 2022). Germany's BMZ funds [BenInnovation](#), EUR 6.5 million over 2022-2026 on structuring the digital sector.

MoUs and other agreements

Benin co-leads a six-country francophone West African framework on AI governance, with Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Mali and Senegal, which the group has taken to the UN Global AI Dialogue (July 2026), the newest of a set of instruments that commit the country to a position rather than to a sum.

The others are of the same kind. The [Cotonou Declaration of November 2025](#) binds its West and Central African signatories to digital-skills and employment targets and to national digital compacts by 2028, with those targets set as regional totals and not allocated between the states that signed them. Benin's data protection authority signed a [cooperation convention with Senegal's Commission de protection des données personnelles](#) in Cotonou in April 2026, and the country joined the 50-in-5 digital public infrastructure campaign in June 2026 as its sixteenth African member, represented by the digital agency ASIN.

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